



Kill A Good Thing?

Why kill a good thing?

Especially when it took so long to establish and build up.

But that is just what the proposers of a ridiculous 36-game Western Athletic Conference baseball schedule will be doing.

It took years for Arizona to build up an intercollegiate baseball schedule that was so attractive that it helped make Tucson a national center for the sport.

And the great spring weather in Tucson has lured many teams out of the midwest, the Rockies and the Pacific Northwest. They've made it a regular migration to come to Tucson to train.

Iowa's Hawkeyes have been coming to Tucson for spring baseball for almost two decades. And this spring they'll be back and two other Big Ten clubs — Ohio State and Michigan — also will come here to play series with Arizona's Wildcats.

Proposal Is Silly

Whoever came up with this idea of having a 36-game schedule in the WAC Southern Division instead of the current 18-game slate must have had too long a winter.

The idea is simply silly.

As Coach Frank Sancet points out if he has to play 36 games with WAC teams there will be only a handful of dates remaining for non-conference games. And out the window would go these spring series with the Big Eight, Big Ten and Pacific-8 teams.

Also lost would be the public relations value of having collegiate baseball teams coming to Tucson for spring training. As it is there's been some clipping of the UA schedule to a point where more teams will be going into the Phoenix area this spring for collegiate spring baseball.

It's one more case of Tucson losing the initiative.

The WAC Race

The addition of the University of Texas at El Paso and Colorado State University to the Western Athletic Conference puts a new twist in the league's baseball play this spring.

In the Southern Division now Arizona, Arizona State and New Mexico will be joined by Texas-El Paso. Colorado State moves into the Northern Division with Wyoming, Utah and Brigham Young.

The word from the North is that this will be the strongest that division has ever been — and you'll remember that last year Brigham Young knocked off Arizona for the WAC championship.

Bud Daniel, the veteran Wyoming coach, puts it this way: "Everyone is going to be improved in the Northern Division this spring. I think BYU has the edge, but it's going to be a real tough race."

In the Southern Division the edge once again goes to Arizona and Arizona State. New Mexico Coach Bob Leigh is hoping to find some more pitching before he'll call his ball club a contender.

And Texas-El Paso, short on scholarships for baseball, sits a step behind New Mexico.

The Texans should have no difficulty consoling themselves if they don't win the WAC championship; their coach, the ex-major leaguer Andy Cohen, has a full-time job with a beer company in El Paso.